🧩 INSTRUCTOR-LED COURSE SYLLABUS · WORDPRESS

PHP and WordPress Development

An instructor-led course in 18 three-hour sessions, in two parts. Set up a professional WordPress 7.1 development site, learn how WordPress works inside, build a custom block theme, then a plugin with custom post types, blocks, REST endpoints, tests and a real deployment: the Pages & Co. bookstore website, launched. Part 1, Themes (8 sessions), also runs on its own.

Course site: rays-php-wordpress.netlify.app

`18 sessions × 3 h` `54 class hours` `31 lessons` `2–3 h homework per session`

`Part 1 alone: 8 sessions` `WordPress 7.1 · PHP 8.5`

📚 COURSE DESCRIPTION

WordPress runs a large share of the web, and most of the paid work around it is development: themes, plugins, blocks, integrations and the upkeep of real client sites. This course teaches it the way professionals work in 2026: on a local Docker site with WP-CLI, debugging and a mail catcher, with WordPress's own conventions for PHP, hooks, security, internationalization and deployment.

Every command and every listing in the course was run on WordPress 7.1.3 with PHP 8.5 and MySQL 9.7 and shows its real output, with notes wherever PHP 8.4, MariaDB or other hosts differ. One project runs through every lesson: the website of **Pages & Co.**, the bookstore of PHP Foundations and MySQL Foundations, from an empty block theme to a tested, deployed site.

🎯 By the end you will be able to

- Run a reproducible WordPress 7.1 development site in Docker, control it with WP-CLI, and read every error in debug.log
- Write PHP the WordPress way: coding standards, escaping, sanitizing and translation functions, callbacks and hooks
- Explain WordPress's request lifecycle, file structure and database tables, and extend it with actions and filters
- Build a custom block theme with theme.json, templates, patterns and style variations, a child theme, and classic templates with the Loop and WP_Query
- Build a structured plugin with custom post types, taxonomies, meta, settings, custom tables and shortcodes, secured with nonces, capabilities and prepared SQL
- Develop static, dynamic and interactive blocks with @wordpress/scripts, block bindings and the Interactivity API
- Use and extend the REST API, call external APIs with caching and scheduled tasks, test, profile, translate and make a site accessible
- Package, deploy and maintain a WordPress site, and launch a complete project of your own

Part 1 only: Sessions 1 to 8 (24 class hours, 13 lessons) run as a complete short course: from a local development site to a custom block theme, a child theme and classic templates, ending with the Part 1 project and assessment. Part 2, Plugins to Launch (Sessions 9 to 18), can follow later, or run on its own for learners who already have the Part 1 skills.

✅ PREREQUISITES

- **PHP Foundations** and **MySQL Foundations** (rays-php.netlify.app, rays-mysql.netlify.app) or equivalent experience: functions and arrays, forms with validation and escaping, classes and namespaces, Composer, SQL SELECT, INSERT and JOIN.
- A Windows 10/11 (with WSL 2), macOS or 64-bit Linux laptop that runs Docker, with 8 GB of memory or more and a few gigabytes of free disk space, on which you may install software.
- The course site is set up at home before Session 1, following Lesson 1.2: Docker, the pagesco-dev project, WP-CLI and Mailpit. Module 6 adds Node.js 24 (or its Docker image).
- Starting with Part 2 only: Part 1 or equivalent WordPress experience (hooks, a block theme with theme.json, the Loop and WP_Query, functions.php).

💡 FORMAT

18 sessions × 3 hours = 54 class hours, one or two lessons per session (Session 8 teaches no new lesson: it is the Part 1 project studio and assessment; Sessions 7 and 17 teach one lesson each and give the rest of the time to project work: the Part 1 project, then the final project), in two parts: **Part 1, Themes** (Sessions 1 to 8) and **Part 2, Plugins to Launch** (Sessions 9 to 18). Every lesson on the course site is written for a solo learner and takes about 100 to 150 minutes, so two lessons do not fit whole in one room session. The room protects what is hardest alone: the **mental model**, a **live demo** you type along with, a **guided lab** with help on hand, and **starting** each lesson project. At home you finish the projects and do each lesson's exercises, quiz and journal entry on the free course site: about **two to three hours** between sessions.

Each session runs 0:00 to 3:00: a warm-up on last session, the first lesson, a 10-minute break, the second lesson, and a wrap-up with an exit ticket and the next bring list. Session 7 teaches one lesson and starts the Part 1 project; Session 8 is a studio for the Part 1 project and the Part 1 assessment; Sessions 17 and 18 give most of their time to the final-project studio.

> **Part 1 only:** Sessions 1 to 8 (24 class hours, 13 lessons) run as a complete short course: from a local development site to a custom block theme, a child theme and classic templates, ending with the Part 1 project and assessment. Part 2, Plugins to Launch (Sessions 9 to 18), can follow later, or run on its own for learners who already have the Part 1 skills.

Twice weekly: 9 weeks for the full course (Part 1 alone: 4 weeks). Two homework sets a week, so plan on four to six hours outside class.

Weekly: 18 weeks (Part 1 alone: 8), with a full week for each homework set.

Intensive days: two sessions a day; homework becomes evening practice and the final project is finished afterward.

📖 SESSION BY SESSION

Lesson titles link to the lesson pages on the course site. Homework is the time to finish that session's lesson projects, exercises, quizzes and journal entries.

SESSION	LESSONS	WHAT YOU WILL BE ABLE TO DO	HOMEWORK
PART 1: THEMES · SESSIONS 1 TO 8			

SESSION	LESSONS	WHAT YOU WILL BE ABLE TO DO	HOMEWORK
1 **WordPress for Developers and Your Local Environment** SETUP	1.1 WordPress for Developers 1.2 Your Local Development Environment	Describe WordPress as a developer sees it, follow one request through core, and have the course's Docker site with WP-CLI, debugging and Mailpit running on your own laptop.	2–3 h
2 **PHP the WordPress Way and the Content Model** WORDPRESS INSIDE	1.3 PHP the WordPress Way 2.1 The Content Model	Write PHP to WordPress's coding standards with its escaping, sanitizing and translation functions and callbacks, and work with posts, pages, users, roles and block markup.	2–3 h
3 **Core Architecture, the Database and Hooks** WORDPRESS INSIDE	2.2 Core Architecture & the Database 2.3 The Hooks System	Find your way through WordPress's files, load order and database tables with SQL and WP-CLI, and change WordPress with actions, filters and your own hooks.	2–3 h
4 **Theme Anatomy and Building a Block Theme** BLOCK THEMES	3.1 Theme Anatomy & the Template Hierarchy 3.2 Building a Block Theme	Explain block, classic and hybrid themes and the template hierarchy, and build the Pages & Co. block theme with theme.json, templates and template parts. Includes Checkpoint 1.	2–3 h
5 **Patterns, Style Variations and Child Themes** BLOCK THEMES	3.3 Patterns, Style Variations & the Site Editor 3.4 Child Themes & Customizing Existing Themes	Add patterns and a style variation, move Site Editor changes back into code, and customize an existing theme safely with a child theme.	2–3 h
6 **The Loop and Custom Queries** CLASSIC THEMES	4.1 The Loop & Template Tags 4.2 Custom Queries	Write classic templates with the Loop, template tags and conditional tags, and query content with WP_Query, pre_get_posts and pagination.	2–3 h
7 **functions.php: Supports, Assets, Menus & Widgets** CLASSIC THEMES PART 1 PROJECT	4.3 functions.php: Supports, Assets, Menus & Widgets	Declare theme supports, enqueue versioned assets, and register menus and widget areas accessibly and translatably; then start the Part 1 project in a studio.	2–3 h
8 **Part 1 Project and Assessment** PART 1 PROJECT	Project studio and assessment	Finish the Part 1 theme project in a studio session, then show what you learned in the Part 1 assessment.	2–3 h

SESSION	LESSONS	WHAT YOU WILL BE ABLE TO DO	HOMEWORK
PART 2: PLUGINS TO LAUNCH · SESSIONS 9 TO 18			
9 **Your First Plugin and Custom Post Types** PLUGINS	5.1 Your First Plugin 5.2 Custom Post Types, Taxonomies & Meta	Structure a plugin with headers, activation and uninstall, a namespace and Composer autoloading, and add the Book post type, Genre taxonomy and book meta.	2–3 h
10 **Security and the Settings API** PLUGINS	5.3 Security in WordPress 5.4 Admin Pages, Settings API & Options	Validate, sanitize and escape every value, protect forms with nonces and capabilities, and build an admin settings page with the Settings API.	2–3 h
11 **Custom Tables, Shortcodes and Block Setup** PLUGINS BLOCKS	5.5 Shortcodes, $wpdb & Custom Tables 6.1 Block Development Setup	Decide when a custom table is right and create it with versioned migrations, write shortcodes with $wpdb, and set up block development with Node 24 and create-block.	2–3 h
12 **Static and Dynamic Blocks** BLOCKS	6.2 Static Blocks: Attributes, Controls & Supports 6.3 Dynamic Blocks & Block Bindings	Build static blocks with attributes, controls and supports, and dynamic blocks rendered in PHP, with block bindings to post meta.	2–3 h
13 **The Interactivity API and Using the REST API** BLOCKS APIS	6.4 The Interactivity API 7.1 Using the REST API	Make a block interactive with the Interactivity API, and use the REST API with authentication and apiFetch. Includes Checkpoint 2.	3 h
14 **Custom Endpoints, External APIs and Cron** APIS	7.2 Custom REST Endpoints 7.3 External APIs, Transients & WP-Cron	Register custom REST endpoints with permissions, arguments and schemas, and call external APIs with transients and scheduled WP-Cron tasks.	2–3 h
15 **Debugging, Testing and Performance** PROFESSIONAL WORKFLOW	8.1 Debugging & Testing 8.2 Performance & Caching	Debug systematically, check code with PHPCS and PHPUnit, and find and fix slow queries, caching and asset-loading problems.	2–3 h
16 **Distribution and Deployment** PROFESSIONAL WORKFLOW FINAL PROJECT	8.3 Internationalization, Accessibility & Distribution 8.4 Deployment & Maintenance	Internationalize and audit a plugin and theme for accessibility, prepare them for distribution, and deploy and maintain a site. The final-project brief is handed out.	2–3 h

SESSION	LESSONS	WHAT YOU WILL BE ABLE TO DO	HOMEWORK
17 **Final Project Kickoff and Studio I** FINAL PROJECT	9.1 Final Project: Launch the Pages & Co. Website	Plan the final project from its brief and build its core: theme, plugin, block and REST endpoint, with milestone check-ins in the room.	2–3 h
18 **Final Project Studio II, Showcase and Next Steps** FINAL PROJECT	9.1 Final Project: Launch the Pages & Co. Website 9.2 Next Steps: Headless, AI in Core & Your Career	Finish, test and launch the final project, present it, and plan your next steps: headless WordPress, AI in core, contributing and your career.	2–3 h

Total out-of-class time: about 37 hours or more across the course.

🕑 SESSION OUTLINES

Times run from the start of each session (0:00 to 3:00). Shift the block to any start time.

SESSION 1 WordPress for Developers and Your Local Environment

You build: 1.1 a first look at WordPress in your browser and the Pages & Co. site plan you will build from in every module; **1.2** the Pages & Co. development site at http://localhost:8080, checked end to end by a health-check script

0:00–0:30	Welcome, environment check and diagnostic
0:30–1:20	1.1 WordPress for Developers frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–2:50	1.2 Your Local Development Environment frame and mental model, install clinic, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 2 PHP the WordPress Way and the Content Model

You build: 1.3 pagesco_book_card(), a helper that renders a book card the WordPress way and passes PHPCS with zero problems; **2.1** the Pages & Co. starter content: staff accounts for Maria (editor) and Devon (author), the About Us, Contact and Events pages, and three News posts

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:20	`1.3` PHP the WordPress Way frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–2:50	`2.1` The Content Model frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 3 Core Architecture, the Database and Hooks

You build: 2.2 a database inventory of the Pages & Co. site, once in SQL and once in PHP with $wpdb (the site itself stays unchanged); **2.3** pagesco-site.php, a must-use plugin that shows the Pages & Co. store notice and offers its own hooks

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:15	`2.2` Core Architecture & the Database frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:15–1:25	*Break*
1:25–2:50	`2.3` The Hooks System frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 4 Theme Anatomy and Building a Block Theme

You build: 3.1 a template map of the Pages & Co. site (the template plan for your own theme) and a throwaway classic theme that you turn hybrid and then block, step by step; **3.2** the pagesco block theme (style.css, theme.json, two template parts, six templates) and make it the active theme of Pages & Co.

> Checkpoint 1 (30 minutes): a short task on Modules 1 and 2.

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–0:40	**Checkpoint 1 (Modules 1–2)**
0:40–1:20	`3.1` Theme Anatomy & the Template Hierarchy frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–1:40	`3.1` Theme Anatomy & the Template Hierarchy start the lesson project
1:40–2:50	`3.2` Building a Block Theme frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 5 Patterns, Style Variations and Child Themes

You build: 3.3 three patterns, two section styles, the Evening style variation, the Vollkorn web font, a synced "Opening hours" pattern and a front page for Pages & Co.; **3.4** pagesco-tt5-child, a child theme of Twenty Twenty-Five with the shop's palette, footer and functions, left installed while pagesco stays the active theme

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:20	`3.3` Patterns, Style Variations & the Site Editor frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–2:50	`3.4` Child Themes & Customizing Existing Themes frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project, which tool for which change?
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 6 The Loop and Custom Queries

You build: 4.1 pagesco-classic, a classic theme for Pages & Co. with templates, template parts and a theme.json, active for the rest of Module 4; **4.2** functions.php with a pre_get_posts callback, paginated news, a front-page.php with several Loops, and a related-posts box for pagesco-classic

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:20	`4.1` The Loop & Template Tags frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–2:50	`4.2` Custom Queries frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project, which query?
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 7 functions.php: Supports, Assets, Menus & Widgets

You build: 4.3 the finished pagesco-classic (supports, stylesheet, menu script, primary menu, footer widget area, skip link, translations) and pagesco's first functions.php with a "Pages & Co." pattern category

> One lesson, then the Part 1 project brief and a first studio block.

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:20	`4.3` functions.php: Supports, Assets, Menus & Widgets frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–1:45	`4.3` functions.php: Supports, Assets, Menus & Widgets accessibility, translation and Mistake 1
1:45–1:55	**Part 1 project kickoff: the brief**
1:55–2:05	**Part 1 project studio: Milestone 1**
2:05–2:25	**Part 1 project studio: Milestone 2 started**
2:25–2:40	**Part 1 project studio: plan Milestone 3**
2:40–2:50	**Studio check-in**
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 8 Part 1 Project and Assessment

> Part 1 project studio, assessment and review. When Part 1 runs on its own, this session closes the course.

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–0:25	Part 1 review
0:25–1:15	**Part 1 project studio**
1:15–1:25	*Break*
1:25–1:35	Part 1 assessment: setup
1:35–2:35	Part 1 assessment
2:35–2:50	**Review and showcase**
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 9 Your First Plugin and Custom Post Types

You build: 5.1 the pagesco-books plugin skeleton (namespace PagesCo\Books, Composer autoload, a "Bookseller" role on activation, cleanup on uninstall) with its first feature, the store-notice additions moved out of pagesco-site.php; **5.2** the book post type, the genre taxonomy, book meta, a "Book details" meta box and admin columns as features of pagesco-books, with eleven books seeded into the catalog

0:00–0:30	Opening Part 2: refresher, starting note and environment check
0:30–1:35	`5.1` Your First Plugin frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:35–1:45	*Break*
1:45–2:50	`5.2` Custom Post Types, Taxonomies & Meta frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 10 Security and the Settings API

You build: 5.3 a hardened BookMetaBox save path and a nonce-protected, capability-checked "Mark sold out" row action in pagesco-books; **5.4** a Settings > Pages & Co. Books page that stores pagesco_books_settings and controls the store notice

0:00–0:15	Warm-up
0:15–1:25	`5.3` Security in WordPress frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:25–1:35	*Break*
1:35–2:50	`5.4` Admin Pages, Settings API & Options frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 11 Custom Tables, Shortcodes and Block Setup

You build: 5.5 the {prefix}pagesco_events table with a versioned migration, six seeded events, and the [pagesco_events] and [pagesco_book] shortcodes on the Events page and the book club post; **6.1** the first draft of the pagesco/book-card block in pagesco-books/src/blocks/, built into build/blocks/ and registered by a new Blocks feature

0:00–0:15	Warm-up
0:15–1:20	`5.5` Shortcodes, $wpdb & Custom Tables frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–2:50	`6.1` Block Development Setup frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 12 Static and Dynamic Blocks

You build: 6.2 the finished static pagesco/book-card block (title, author, recommendation, link, heading level, "Staff pick" badge, colors and spacing, one deprecation), with a staff pick for The Hobbit on the Staff picks post; **6.3** the dynamic pagesco/book-list block with genre variations, a pagesco/book binding source, and a single-book.html template whose author, price, stock and facts come from the book's meta

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:15	`6.2` Static Blocks: Attributes, Controls & Supports frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:15–1:25	*Break*
1:25–2:50	`6.3` Dynamic Blocks & Block Bindings frame and mental model, live demo: render.php, guided lab, live demo: block bindings, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 13 The Interactivity API and Using the REST API

You build: 6.4 the pagesco/book-filter block: the whole catalog with genre links that filter instantly, keep the address in step, and work without JavaScript, on a new "Find a Book" page; **7.1** an application password for the shop's inventory script, and a "Stock at a glance" dashboard widget that reads and updates books through the REST API with apiFetch

> Checkpoint 2 (30 minutes): a short task on Modules 5 and 6.

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:05	6.4 The Interactivity API frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:05–1:15	*Break*
1:15–2:20	7.1 Using the REST API frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:20–2:50	**Checkpoint 2 (Modules 5 and 6)**
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 14 Custom Endpoints, External APIs and Cron

You build: 7.2 the pagesco/v1 API of the shop: GET /books (filter by genre and stock, sort by price, page size from the Books per list setting), GET /books/<id>, and GET and POST /events on the events table, with the first event added through it; **7.3** a supplier client in the plugin, a cached Supplier column on the Books screen, the daily pagesco_books_daily_sync job (which also removes past events), and the pagesco/check-stock ability

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:20	7.2 Custom REST Endpoints frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:20–1:30	*Break*
1:30–2:50	7.3 External APIs, Transients & WP-Cron frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 15 Debugging, Testing and Performance

You build: **8.1** a lint and test setup for pagesco-books: Composer dev dependencies and scripts, a phpcs.xml.dist ruleset with a clean run, a .wp-env.json test environment, and twelve PHPUnit tests for the shortcode, the books route, the supplier client and the daily sync; **8.2** a cached events query, an autoloaded settings row, a one-query catalog lookup for the supplier, and a hero image that no longer shifts the front page and arrives sooner, with the numbers before and after

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:15	8.1 Debugging & Testing frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:15–1:25	*Break*
1:25–2:35	8.2 Performance & Caching frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:35–2:50	8.1 Debugging & Testing + 8.2 Debrief
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 16 Distribution and Deployment

You build: **8.3** an opt-in "delete all shop data" setting tested both ways, a Spanish translation of the plugin and its blocks, three accessibility fixes, and release 1.1.0 of the plugin: readme, ZIP, and a Plugin Check run with no errors; **8.4** a Git repository for the shop's code, release files built from tagged commits, and a production rehearsal of Pages & Co. at http://localhost:8081 that you launch, check, back up, restore and update to plugin 1.1.1

> Final project brief: Reserve & Pick Up, online book reservations for Pages & Co.

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:10	8.3 Internationalization, Accessibility & Distribution frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
1:10–1:20	*Break*
1:20–2:25	8.4 Deployment & Maintenance frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:25–2:50	**Final-project brief (Lesson 9.1)**
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 17 Final Project Kickoff and Studio I

You build: 9.1 Reserve & Pick Up: a holds table, two settings, a service class, an email, three REST endpoints, three form handlers, a staff screen, two blocks, live prices on the front page, five tests and a smoke test, released as Pages & Co. Books 1.2.0 and theme 1.2.0 and deployed to the rehearsal server

> Studio: plan and build, with milestone check-ins.

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:25	9.1 Final Project: Launch the Pages & Co. Website frame: the brief, the layers, the rubric, live demo: three mistakes before you build, studio: Milestone 1, plan and baseline, studio: Milestone 2, the data
1:25–1:35	*Break*
1:35–2:50	9.1 Final Project: Launch the Pages & Co. Website guided lab, studio: Milestone 3, the rules and the email, studio: Milestone 4 (start), the doors
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up

SESSION 18 Final Project Studio II, Showcase and Next Steps

You build: 9.1 Reserve & Pick Up: a holds table, two settings, a service class, an email, three REST endpoints, three form handlers, a staff screen, two blocks, live prices on the front page, five tests and a smoke test, released as Pages & Co. Books 1.2.0 and theme 1.2.0 and deployed to the rehearsal server; **9.2** a three-file headless storefront for the shop's REST API, a model's-eye test of the pagesco/check-stock ability, a release-watch routine, and a portfolio-ready README in your Git repository

> Studio, then a showcase of every learner's project.

0:00–0:10	Warm-up
0:10–1:15	9.1 Final Project: Launch the Pages & Co. Website studio: Milestone 7, quality, studio: Milestone 8, release 1.2.0, studio: Milestone 9, the code-only deploy
1:15–1:25	*Break*
1:25–1:55	9.1 Final Project: Launch the Pages & Co. Website showcase
1:55–2:50	9.2 Next Steps: Headless, AI in Core & Your Career frame and mental model, live demo, guided lab, start the lesson project
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up and course close

📅 SAMPLE SCHEDULES

No dates: fit them to your calendar. "Twice weekly" puts two sessions in each week (Day 1 and Day 2), finishing in week 9.

SESSION	TWICE WEEKLY (≈9 WEEKS)	WEEKLY (18 WEEKS)
1 WordPress for Developers and Your Local Environment	Week 1, Day 1	Week 1
2 PHP the WordPress Way and the Content Model	Week 1, Day 2	Week 2

SESSION	TWICE WEEKLY (≈9 WEEKS)	WEEKLY (18 WEEKS)
3 Core Architecture, the Database and Hooks	Week 2, Day 1	Week 3
4 Theme Anatomy and Building a Block Theme	Week 2, Day 2	Week 4
5 Patterns, Style Variations and Child Themes	Week 3, Day 1	Week 5
6 The Loop and Custom Queries	Week 3, Day 2	Week 6
7 functions.php: Supports, Assets, Menus & Widgets	Week 4, Day 1	Week 7
8 Part 1 Project and Assessment	Week 4, Day 2	Week 8
9 Your First Plugin and Custom Post Types	Week 5, Day 1	Week 9
10 Security and the Settings API	Week 5, Day 2	Week 10
11 Custom Tables, Shortcodes and Block Setup	Week 6, Day 1	Week 11
12 Static and Dynamic Blocks	Week 6, Day 2	Week 12
13 The Interactivity API and Using the REST API	Week 7, Day 1	Week 13
14 Custom Endpoints, External APIs and Cron	Week 7, Day 2	Week 14
15 Debugging, Testing and Performance	Week 8, Day 1	Week 15
16 Distribution and Deployment	Week 8, Day 2	Week 16
17 Final Project Kickoff and Studio I	Week 9, Day 1	Week 17
18 Final Project Studio II, Showcase and Next Steps	Week 9, Day 2	Week 18

🏁 CHECKPOINTS, ASSESSMENT AND PROJECT

- **Self-checks and exit tickets** in every session are practice, not grades: they tell you and your instructor what to revisit.
- **Checkpoint 1 (Session 4)** and **Checkpoint 2 (Session 13)**, 30 minutes each: short individual tasks on the modules just finished, scored with a short rubric.
- **Part 1 project and assessment (Sessions 7 and 8):** a small theme for a client, built in the studio, and an individual assessment on Modules 1 to 4, scored with rubrics. When Part 1 runs on its own, they are the course's final assessment.
- **Final project (Sessions 16 to 18).** From a short brief (Reserve & Pick Up: customers reserve Pages & Co. books online and pick them up in the store), you plan and build it across the theme, the plugin, a block and a REST endpoint, secure and test it, deploy it and present the result. A well-reasoned modest project scores as well as an elaborate one.

🧰 REQUIRED SOFTWARE AND DATA

- **Docker:** Docker Desktop (Windows with WSL 2, macOS) or Docker Engine with the Compose plugin (Linux); the course project runs WordPress 7.1 on PHP 8.5, MySQL 9.7, WP-CLI and Mailpit in containers
- **A code editor:** VS Code (free) with a PHP extension such as PHP Intelephense; any code editor will do

- **Node.js 24 LTS (Part 2):** for block development from Module 6, or the official node:24 Docker image
- **Composer (Part 2):** through the official composer:2 Docker image; nothing to install
- **No accounts or paid tools:** everything runs on an ordinary laptop; WordPress Playground and wp-env are shown as free alternatives, and deployment options are compared in Lesson 8.4

The course site is set up once, at home, before Session 1, following Lesson 1.2 (Docker and the pagesco-dev project). Your instructor sends a setup guide and an environment check a week ahead; Session 1 has an install clinic for anything that went wrong. Node.js 24 and the Composer image are needed from Part 2; Session 9 checks them.

✉️ FOR INSTRUCTORS

Want to teach this course? A complete instructor kit for PHP and WordPress Development (facilitator guides, slides, labs, workbooks, answer keys and assessments for all 18 sessions) is available under license. Ask about the instructor kit.

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